parties like the Purbo Banglar Communist Party, the Purba Banglar Samyabadi Dal, the East Pakistan Communist Party and the Purba Sarbahara Party has not yet indicated any active support for the present regime. They have fairly well-organised underground cadres who are guerrilla-oriented and could, if in opposition to the government, be expected to activate widespread minor attacks on isolated police stations, rural banks, etc. Their inspiration, however, is Maoist and they are unlikely to create any difficulty for the present regime for the time being till the attitude of China becomes clear.

The R&AW, which was keeping an eye on influential players after the Sheikh Mujib era, had identified A.V.M. Towab, chief of air staff, as a gradually emerging challenger to Zia's pre-eminence in Bangladesh. As a repatriated officer with avowed pro-West and pro-Pak-istani leanings, his thinking was also in line with leaders embedded in the government yet unhappy over the recent developments in the country. There were intelligence reports to indicate that he had, behind the scenes, been trying to undermine Zia's position and move the government towards a more pro-Pakistani stance. R&AW had learnt that Towab was trying to get back some officers from Libya where they had fled after the coup, with an eye on creating a counterweight to the growing dominance of Ziaur Rahman.

Though he hoped for an internal uprising against Ziaur Rahman, Suntook believed that the armed forces were not in favour of supporting any particular party which was why no military leader had publicly expressed the view that elections should be delayed beyond the declared deadline of February 1977. The R&AW felt that the armed forces in power could be